

LANDER ADVANCE

Game Manual

1 Prologue

«Everyone must do their bit.»

But what is mine?

I spent years chasing a star I could never quite see, and in all honesty, I never imagined my path could smell of. . .

What on earth is that smell? Candy floss?

* * *

I had only just earned my pilot's licence when they arrived; had they shown up a little earlier, I would have saved myself no end of bother.

The crowd was milling around the enormous screen in the centre of the square and I, in all honesty, hardly paid any attention: I was used to wandering off in my own thoughts without truly watching where I was heading, or who was around me.

"No bloody way!" someone shouted from the middle, or something rather more foul-mouthed; my earphones and the slurp of my fizzy drink kept me from hearing properly. I turned towards the screen, expecting yet another missed goal by some footballer. How wrong I was.

I had grown up on sci-fi tales of colossal, technologically advanced starships capable of ploughing through the dark, infinite spacetime tide in a humanly reasonable amount of

time.

Who on earth would ever travel without being able to come back and post their holiday snaps on social media?

I had heard tell of flashing lights, lasers and sleek, aerodynamic shapes of questionable utility.

My sister discovered those long before the engineers in those books ever did.

They all spoke of impossible voyages, galactic wars and propulsion methods that, throughout my studies, struck me as equal parts daydream and madness.

Instead, onto that screen flashed footage from a satellite orbiting the Moon to capture high-resolution video of our beloved neighbour.

Since when have people cared so much about space exploration?

I asked myself in earnest, perhaps with a pinch of malice, perhaps. . .yes, definitely with an accusatory tone.

The regolith, the craters, the LEM, a circus tent. . .

A CIRCUS TENT?!

2 Interview No. 339

Remember to smile at the applicants.

Interviewer: «Everyone must do their bit.»

Pilot: «I haven't quite grasped what mine is supposed to be.»

Interviewer: «We have a . . . what's it called again?»

Clown: «Giovanni.» *(He was sitting next to my interviewer, staring right at me.)*

Interviewer: «No, I meant the enormous mothership cannon threatening to obliterate Earth unless we manage to pack out all the circus tents they've pitched across the Solar System.»

Clown: «Yes, Giovanni.»

(He crossed one leg over the other, then swapped them back, looking distinctly uneasy, whilst maintaining that infernal grin.)

Pilot: «Hang on, so it's actually true?» *(I asked, dumbfounded.)*

Interviewer: «An unknown alien species is threatening our planet; their population, currently on holiday, will be stopping by the various big tents pitched across the celestial bodies. They will spare us only if the audience laughs at every single show.»

(The clown smiled, giving two thumbs up, visibly trembling.)

Pilot: «So my destiny is being decided by a board of directors wearing red noses?!»

The clown locked eyes with him and, at last, with a swift squeeze of his bulbous red nose, produced a loud, playful honk.

3 Mission Planning

Clown: «Start wherever you fancy, mind you; we have to fill every big tent on every celestial body with a solid surface: wouldn't want to go taking an accidental dip, would we? HAHA! Honk!»

Pilot: «This is supposed to be my first trial day...»

Clown: «Fair enough, if it's your first time, kick off with the Moon. If you come back alive, you can pick the other destinations. Now I'll hand you over to Nasino, the AI who'll guide you through the organisation.»

3.1 Selecting the celestial body

Hello! I'm Nasino!!

Select your target here—`djakç°@38`—My mistake.

If it's your first time... CONGRATULATIONS!

You will only be able to choose the Moon. When selecting a Celestial Body, keep a sharp eye on the fundamental parameters:

- **"Starting"**: indicates the altitude below which you must take manual control of the lander, because there's not a chance in hell I'm doing everything myself!
- **"Gravity"**: dictates how rapidly you are drawn towards your demise. A higher value means your thrusters will have to work much harder.

- **Description:** handy for understanding what sort of mess you're getting yourself into.
- **Reviews:** customer reviews? I shan't be showing you those.

3.2 Choosing the landing area

Right, you can't just go landing on the big tent, that wouldn't be very polite!

For each Celestial Body, you may select one of the three available landing zones.

The zones are not all alike: each features distinct topography, its own description and a difficulty rating, "**Diff**". Zones with higher difficulty will grant a higher multiplier to your final score in the event of a successful touchdown.

4 Flight Configuration and Resources

It's not you we need; or rather, we only need you to deliver your crew members down in one piece so they can make the aliens chuckle. . .

For now, your selection is restricted to a single crewmate alongside yourself, seeing as you're on probation. Let's minimise collateral damage, nothing personal.

4.1 Selecting the lander

What craft will you use to accomplish your mission? The choice is yours.

- **"Crew"**: indicates how much fresh meat you can haul. Increasing the headcount increases the lander's mass, with direct consequences on fuel consumption.
- **"Mass"**: total dry mass to transport. More mass means more thrust required and more fuel burnt.
- **"Fuel"**: maximum propellant capacity available. Watch it closely!
- **"Thrust"**: maximum thrust of the main engines to counteract gravity.
- **"RCS"**: thrust of the small auxiliary thrusters for rotation and translation: do try landing lopsided and let me know how that pans out.

4.2 Resource selection (Critical Stage)

WARNING: The Circus accepts no liability for loss of human life. The pilot bears sole responsibility.

Think of it like a trip to the butcher's: with "Crew", you are choosing your cuts of meat. The more you pick, the heavier you get, and you already know the drill for the rest.

Perhaps one day we will award distinct score values for each individual crew member. What's that? Why are we talking about scores? Because it's jolly good fun, obviously!

5 Cockpit Controls and Flight Deck

I know you're an ace pilot, but a quick refresher certainly won't do you any harm.

5.1 Flight & Manoeuvring Controls (Cockpit)

Let's kick off with the essentials: how to avoid crashing into bits.

- **A: Main Engine** - Fires the primary vertical thruster to counteract gravity. Consumes propellant.
- **D-PAD Left / Right: Lateral RCS Translation** - Delivers horizontal manoeuvring thrust to the left or right.
- **D-PAD Up / Down: Vertical RCS Translation** - Delivers translational thrust upwards/-forwards or downwards/backwards.
- **L (Left Shoulder): LEM Clockwise Rotation / Port Tilt** - Engages the RCS thruster pair to roll the module's attitude clockwise.
- **R (Right Shoulder): LEM Counter-Clockwise Rotation / Starboard Tilt** - Engages the RCS thruster pair in the opposite direction (counter-clockwise).
- **B + R: Onboard Radar** - Toggles the radar on/off to check your touchdown point when your eyes fail you.
- **B + L: Landing Lights** - Pitch black out there? This should sort it, I reckon.

- **START: Pause** - Pause: pause is pause.
- **SELECT: Popipopi** - Press it. Go on, do it.

5.2 Menu Navigation Controls

In the selection, configuration and pause menus:

- **A: Confirm / Advance** - Selects the highlighted option, opens technical data sheets, launches flight, or confirms selected entries.
- **B: Back / Cancel** - Returns to the previous screen or cancels the last selection.
- **D-PAD Up / Down: Cursor Movement** - Navigates vertically through landing zones and pause menu entries.
- **D-PAD Left / Right: Selection / Value Adjustment** - Cycles through celestial bodies, lander models and increases/decreases the number of lucky crew members.
- **START: Pause** - Accesses the pause menu during flight.

6 Limitation of Liability Declaration

By accepting the mission and designated target, the pilot acknowledges full awareness that each celestial body carries distinct inherent hazards.

The Circus accepts no responsibility for damages arising from impacts, optical sensor failure, off-axis landings, or an unsatisfied alien audience.